ideology predicated on the centrality of Hinduness to Indianness: the exact opposite of the idea of citizenship advocated by Nehru.

This point of ideological difference is fundamental to understanding the early animosity between Nehru and the Jan Sangh and the visceral dislike that bhakts today have for India's first prime minister. In 1973, Vajpayee would sum the party's position thus: '… if today the Jana Sangh has become the prime target of attacks from our rulers and their communist and Communalist allies, this is essentially because these elements are increasingly becoming conscious of the fact that unlike other Opposition parties, Jana Sangh is not a splinter party formed by any group of malcontents belonging to another party, nor is it a lobby of any vested interests, but it is a party which offers a powerful alternative to the Ruling Congress and seeks to inspire and consolidate the people on the three-plank credo of Nationalism, Democracy and Justice.'[127]

On Muslims and the Antecedents of the Civil Code and Triple Talaq

Exactly like the BJP in 2020, the Sangh in the 1960s responded to charges of communalism by seeing itself as a victim of malignant targeting by opponents whom it saw as communal. When asked about his views on the Uniform Civil Code in Ahmedabad, Madhok argued that the Congress was a communal organisation. 'It lives in communalism. It has a vested interest in communalism. Actually if you go into the results of the last three elections, you will find that it is the communal votes of the Muslim votes or Christian votes, which have been the mainstay of the Congress.'[128]

Jan Sangh leaders understood that most minority groups would not vote for it. The logical culmination of this thought process was for the BJP to ignore the Muslim vote altogether in the 2017 UP election, when the party did not give a single ticket to a Muslim candidate. Why waste time in courting them, its strategists may have reasoned.

One of the triggers of this deep divide was the debate over the Uniform Civil Code. 'When the Hindu Code was being made, Government gave clear assurance in reply to a motion moved by